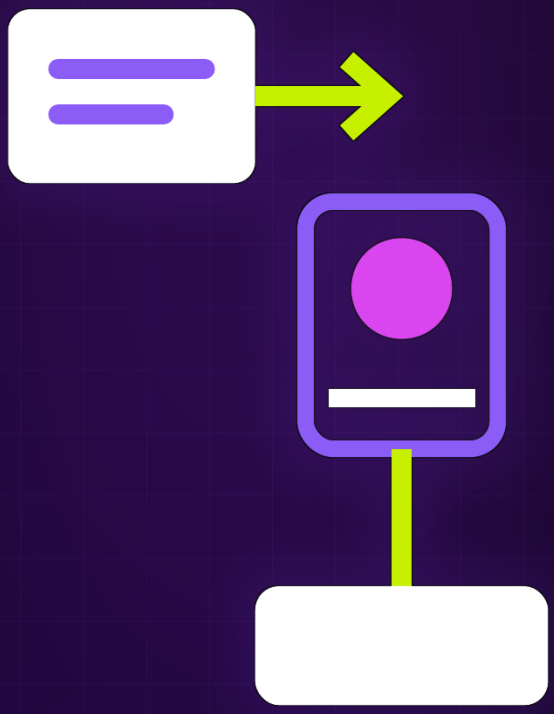
BLINDER TUNNEL MSBUILD EXECUTION

Hunts MSBuild launching a masqueraded RuntimeBroker from a user-writable campaign path.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



REPORT DATE
07 October 2026

STATUS
Untested implementation sketch

PRIMARY PLATFORM
Microsoft Defender XDR

OPERATIONAL VALUE
8.0 / 10

EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

8.0

Hunts MSBuild launching a masqueraded RuntimeBroker from a user-writable campaign path.

CLASSIFICATION

Hunting query

Medium confidence. Source-supported campaign evidence; environmental prevalence is not validated.

1 primary table
1 primary query
0 production claims
4 validation gates

Evidence boundary

A result does not prove exploitation, malicious content, persistence, or BLINDER attribution.

BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

#	Source-supported fact
1	Unit 42 documented a weaponized Visual Studio project overriding GetFrameworkPaths during design-time evaluation.
2	msbuild.exe copied and launched a renamed Microsoft vshost binary as RuntimeBroker.exe under LocalAppData.
3	The path and filename are campaign artifacts and may change.

Detection hypothesis

If the published behavior occurs in a covered endpoint or cloud workload, DeviceProcessEvents should retain the campaign-specific evidence used by this hunt.

Unconfirmed elements

A result does not prove exploitation, malicious content, persistence, or BLINDER attribution.

ATT&CK: T1127 · T1036

TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

DeviceProcessEvents

Microsoft Defender XDR advanced hunting coverage must retain the fields referenced by the query.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

Identity, device, network, file reputation, prevalence, owner, change record, and adjacent-event context.

Requirement	Decision
Primary platform	Microsoft Defender XDR
Primary table	DeviceProcessEvents
Query status	Untested implementation sketch
Classification	Hunting; no alerting before validation

Coverage caveat

An empty result may mean no match, missing telemetry, retention gaps, parser differences, or field sparsity.

PRIMARY KQL

Source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
// MITRE ATT&CK: T1127 (Trusted Developer Utilities Proxy Execution), T1036 (Masquerading)
// Classification: Hunting query - Untested implementation sketch
// Primary platform: Microsoft Defender XDR Advanced Hunting
// Required telemetry: Microsoft Defender for Endpoint / DeviceProcessEvents
// Evidence: Unit 42 observed msbuild.exe launching a renamed vshost.exe as
// RuntimeBroker.exe from %LOCALAPPDATA%\Microsoft\RuntimeBrokers.
// A match supports the source-observed execution shape; it does not prove
// Blinder Tunnel attribution, DLL sideloading, C2, or successful compromise.
DeviceProcessEvents
| where FileName =~ "RuntimeBroker.exe"
| where FolderPath contains @"\AppData\Local\Microsoft\RuntimeBrokers\"
| where InitiatingProcessFileName =~ "msbuild.exe"
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountUpn, FileName, FolderPath,
          ProcessCommandLine, SHA1, ProcessVersionInfoOriginalFileName,
          InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessFolderPath,
          InitiatingProcessCommandLine, ProcessId, InitiatingProcessId,
          ProcessUniqueId, InitiatingProcessUniqueId, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain the raw event, device or account, timestamps, and campaign-matched values.

2

Confirm

Validate field semantics and determine whether the matched object exists.

3

Enrich

Add reputation, prevalence, owner, identity, network, and adjacent-event context.

4

Scope

Search for related execution, persistence, access, and follow-on activity.

Expected benign overlap

Administration, software development, security testing, automation, content inspection, shared infrastructure, or legitimate files may overlap. Tune only after ownership and prevalence are established.

Response boundary

A result does not prove exploitation, malicious content, persistence, or BLINDER attribution.

VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and promotion criteria.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

1. Confirm the primary table and every projected field exist.
2. Replay an authorized benign event matching the query shape.
3. Measure at least 30 days of tenant prevalence and benign overlap.
4. Verify every result retains sufficient evidence for triage.

Decision criteria

Success: the test is visible and real matches remain attributable.

Rejection: benign activity dominates or the campaign artifact is no longer reliable.

Failure: required telemetry or fields are unavailable.

Promotion gate

Do not promote to production until telemetry, prevalence, ownership, and false-positive handling are demonstrated in the target environment.

CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Hunting query

Hunts MSBuild launching a masqueraded RuntimeBroker from a user-writable campaign path.

A result does not prove exploitation, malicious content, persistence, or BLINDER attribution.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1127 · T1036

References

1. PRIMARY RESEARCH
2. Palo Alto Networks Unit 42 — Blinder Tunnel Campaign Targets Iraqi Infrastructure
3. Publication date: 2026-10-06
4. Observed activity: infrastructure staging from 2025-11; campaign active from 2026-03; coding challenge observed 2026-04
5. hxxps://unit42[.]paloaltonetworks[.]com/blinder-tunnel-targets-critical-infrastructure/
6. OFFICIAL SCHEMA DOCUMENTATION
7. Microsoft Learn — DeviceProcessEvents table in the advanced hunting schema
8. Last updated: 2026-08-07; accessed: 2026-10-07
9. hxxps://learn[.]microsoft[.]com/en-us/defender-xdr/advanced-hunting-deviceprocessevents-table
10. MITRE ATT&CK
11. T1127 — Trusted Developer Utilities Proxy Execution
12. hxxps://attack[.]mitre[.]org/techniques/T1127/

Document control

Canonical locked typography and layout. Only the campaign illustration on page 1 is variable.